

Reconciling faith and reason



St. Augustine was a key figure in both the history of Western philosophy and the development of Christianity.

The first significant Christian philosopher was Augustine of Hippo. Although his mother was a Christian, he at first rejected the faith and studied philosophy, flirting for a while with the Persian religion of Manichaeism. It was only after a thorough study of Greek philosophy, and especially Plato and the 'Neo-Platonism' taught by Plotinus, that he converted. Unsurprisingly, his approach to Christianity was coloured by his

philosophy. He believed the two were not incompatible: Christianity is characterized by belief, philosophy by reasoning but, he argued, faith and reason can not only coexist, but are complementary. He suggested that Christianity could absorb the philosophy of Plato without contradicting any of its central beliefs, in order to provide a rational basis for its theology. His work coincided with the adoption of Christianity as the official religion of the Roman Empire, and in his book *The City of God* he explained how it was possible to be a citizen of an earthly community at the same time as living in the eternal and true world of the kingdom of God – an idea adapted from Platonism.